

What is a line - Case Study

New Line

Context

As part of the Pratt MFA Communications Design application, applicants were asked to create a visual response to the prompt:

"What is a line, and what can it do?"

The assignment was intentionally open-ended and was designed less as a test of technical skill than as a way of understanding how applicants think. Rather than approaching the prompt as a formal design exercise, I treated it as a question to be explored.

Process

The project began in a sketchbook. In the lower corner of each page, I drew a single line, changing it slightly from page to page. When the pages were flipped quickly, the line appeared to move.

As I continued drawing, I became interested in how little information was required for a line to become something recognizable. A slight shift could transform it from an abstract mark into an object, a landscape, a letter, or a figure. The same line could become almost anything.

Eventually I stopped thinking about individual drawings and became interested in the larger question behind them: if a line can become anything, then what is a line, really?

The sketchbook eventually ran out of pages, but the idea did not.

Response

To continue the experiment, I translated the flipbook into code. Instead of producing a finite sequence of drawings, I built a system that continuously generates new forms from a single animated line.

The line moves through recognizable and unrecognizable states. It becomes objects, symbols, gestures, and abstractions before dissolving into something else. There is no beginning, end, or final image. The work exists as an ongoing process of transformation.

By making the system generative, the project shifts from describing what a line is to demonstrating what a line can do. The line is not treated as a fixed graphic element but as a structure capable of endless variation.

Reflection

My answer to the prompt was ultimately very simple: a line is not one thing.

A line can become almost anything depending on context, movement, and perception. Rather than defining a line through a single image, I became more interested in creating a system that could continuously explore the question itself.

Looking back, the project feels representative of how I approach design more broadly. Rather than searching for a single answer, I am often interested in building frameworks that generate many possible answers. The line became less important than the rules governing its transformation. Once those rules were established, the work could continue to evolve on its own.

This approach sits somewhere between art, design, and experimentation. My background is in studio art, but I have always been drawn to systematic ways of working—setting parameters, observing outcomes, and using structure as a tool for discovery. In many ways, my approach to design is rooted in that intersection: a scientific approach to art.

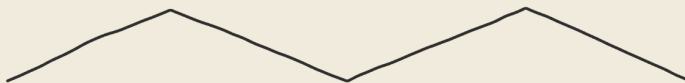
The final piece is therefore less a drawing than an experiment. It asks a simple question and creates a system capable of exploring that question indefinitely. The work never arrives at a definitive answer, but instead demonstrates that the question itself can remain productive.

In that sense, the project is not only an exploration of what a line is and what it can do, but also an early example of the way I think as a designer: creating systems, establishing rules, and using those structures to uncover possibilities that could not have been predicted in advance.

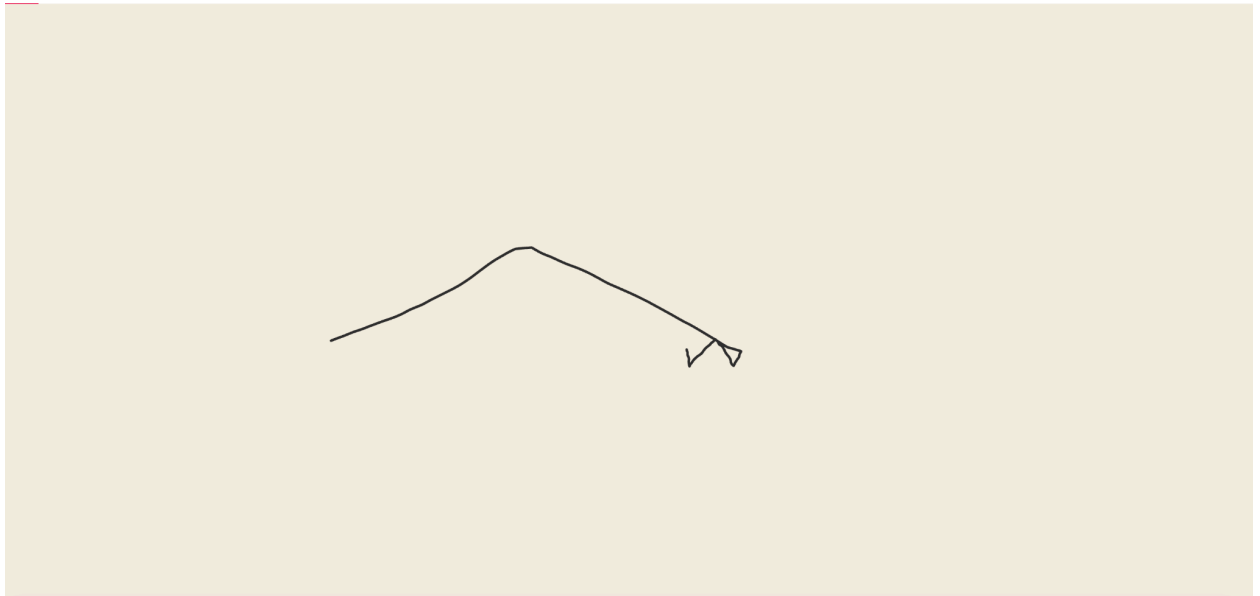
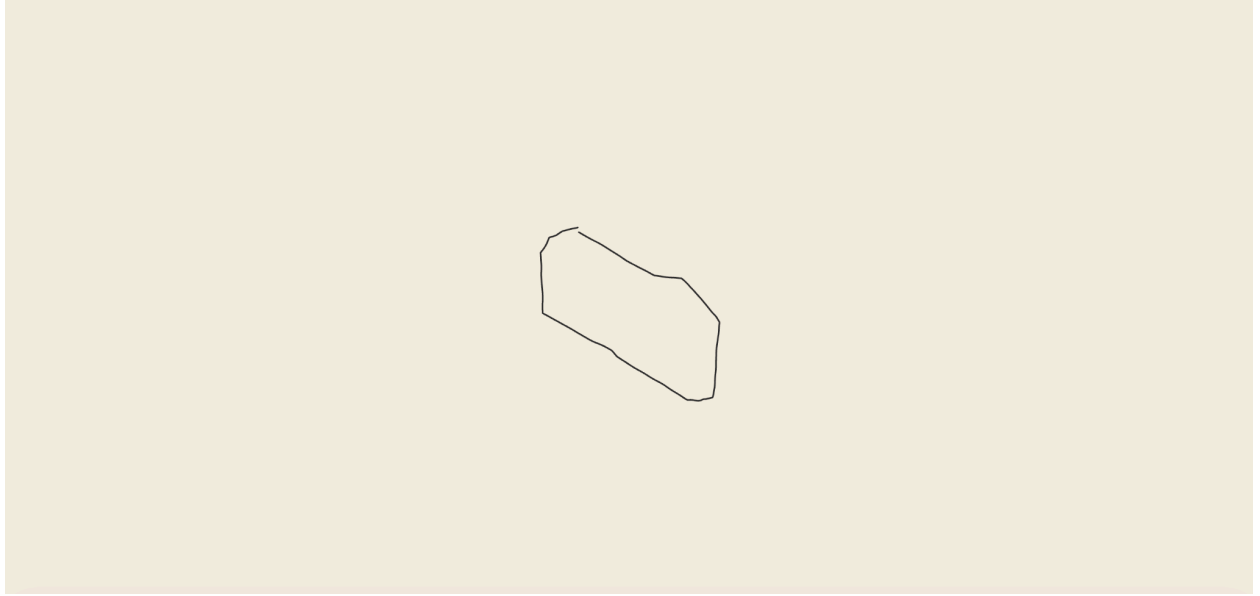
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